



Calakmul

A lost Maya city deep in a tropical forest, dominated by two imposing pyramid temples

Once a thriving city of as many as 50,000 inhabitants, Calakmul, known by the Maya as Ox Te’ Tuun (“Three Stones”), now stands empty, with much of its ruins overgrown by the surrounding jungle. Situated in the UNESCO-protected tropical forest of the Tierras Bajas in the Yucatán Peninsula, Mexico—the heartland of the Maya civilization—the settlement was established in the 1st millennium BCE. It became the seat of a powerful kingdom in the Mesoamerican Classic period (c.250–900 CE). Like several Maya cities, Calakmul was abandoned in the 9th century, but many of its



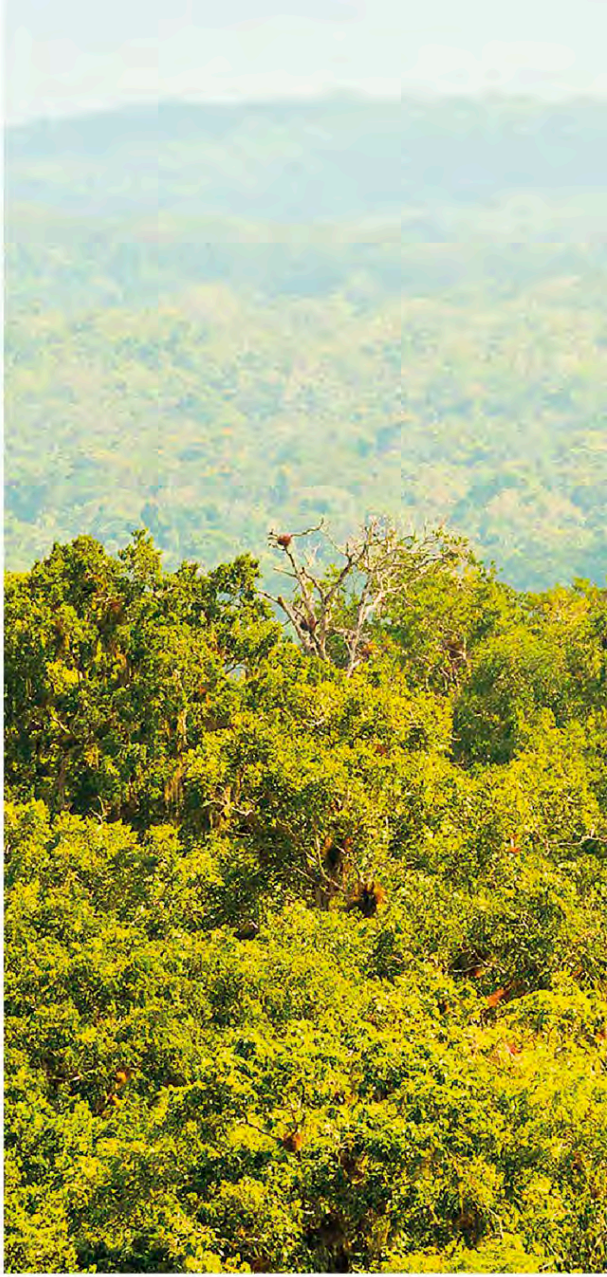
structures are well preserved and have been reclaimed from the forest since the city’s discovery in 1931. Thousands of structures—including residential buildings, tombs, and monuments—have been found, with a wealth of decorative murals, ceramic artifacts, and stone stelae. Dominating these buildings, however, are the two massive pyramid temples that give the city its modern name: Calakmul, “city of two adjacent pyramids.”

◀ **CARVED STELA**
This is one of the 117 stelae found at Calakmul. The stelae featured portraits and inscriptions carved into the soft limestone, commemorating members of the ruling families.

American botanist **Cyrus Lundell** discovered the ruins of Calakmul by chance while working in the rainforest



△ **THE GREAT PYRAMID**
The largest of the pyramids, known as Structure II, or the Great Pyramid, was constructed by building onto an existing pyramid. It contains four separate tombs.



△ **CAPITAL OF A FOREST KINGDOM**
The Maya city of Tikal remained hidden in the lush Guatemalan rainforest until clearance of the vegetation began in the late 19th century.

